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Design Thinking

18 April 2025

Reframing Biases and Harmful Stereotypes

It was my first time working with Photoshop, and I am proud of what I have created for this class. I started brainstorming a lot of ideas to reframe, and reshape, our beliefs and biases for certain individuals and situations. I listed a long number of things that bother me; fear and hate toward immigrants? Human domination over animals? Stereotypes about Muslims in the U.S.? The latter really stuck with me; I long learned about how after 9/11, there has been a lot of hate toward Muslims and anti-Muslim acts in the U.S. Coming from Uzbekistan, a Muslim dominant country, and identifying myself as a liberal Muslim, this topic has been in my mind. How could I talk about Islamophobia without mentioning 9/11? I acknowledge that it is a sad and sensitive topic, but all the research I had done around this topic showed that this event really changed the fate for many Muslims negatively in the U.S, even asking to self-register themselves. Then, I thought about the perception about Muslim women, often being referred to as oppressed and weak, of which I wanted to change the perspectives of my peers. I was surprised by how little my friends here knew about Muslim inventions; every country teaches algebra, but some people hardly knew that Al-Kwarazmi was born in Uzbekistan. Or, the fact that numbers we use today are Arabic numbers. Eventually, I wanted to show something good of Islam as a religion that celebrates and encourages science, pursuit of knowledge, and peace. Coming up with ideas and different ways of looking at societal beliefs was my favorite part of the process.

I was stuck at revisiting my peers' feedback and trying to integrate their suggestions into the posters as revised submission. It was because after seeing my posters so frequently, I almost fell in love with them. I thought about various effects and changes I could make; however, these are minor things, I convinced myself. I asked the opinions of other friends who hadn't yet to see the posters, and I thought they were fine.

Three things that I appreciate having learned through trial and error in this project are: (1) asking various perspectives, especially for design work, is one of the important steps, (2) Internet can be a great help for Adobe Photoshop learning, (3) design could be subjective, each person interpreting my work differently. I hope to put those learning into the future when I will be working to interview people for the project 4.